Ever since 28 September, there had been no feedback on the appreciation that had been sent to Eastern Command. As soon as Dalvi broached the subject with Niranjan Prasad, the 4 Division GOC's reply was disheartening: 'Look, old boy, no one is interested in your bloody appreciation. They are only interested in your D-Day for evicting the Chinese.' Then came the news that Lieutenant General B. M. Kaul had been appointed the GOC of a new corps to speed up operations. It was obvious that there was no one now who could stand up for the men of 7 Brigade.

While Dalvi was still trying to come to grips with these startling revelations, Prasad delivered yet another gem: he wanted the brigade commander and the commanding officers of 2 Rajput and 1/9 GR out of Lumpu heading for the front immediately. He said Kaul would be furious if he found Dalvi or any of the other senior officers in Lumpu and that the party must leave at once. An indignant Dalvi decided to stand his ground saying he saw no reason to shift his headquarters forward and that there was little dignity in 'senior officers scurrying away like thieves in the night. Who are we more afraid of,' he asked, 'the Chinese or our own superior commanders?' By then, Niranjan Prasad was almost frantic with worry. He 'begged' Dalvi to just head off in the general direction of the front. The GOC said he didn't care if the officers sheltered in the nearest yak shed, but they had to go! By noon the brigade commander and his two bewildered COs were sloshing through ankle-deep slush through grazing meadows as they headed off towards Hathung-la. The night was spent three kilometres north of Lumpu, each man wondering what lay ahead of him.

New Delhi awakened on 5 October to front-page headlines in the *Times of India* that proclaimed Kaul was on his way to NEFA to evict the Chinese from Indian soil. If secrecy was to have been part of Kaul's operational plans, he had already ensured that was not possible. (Army HQ later went through the sham of ordering an inquiry to find the source of the leak.)

The Bell helicopter with the new corps commander on board landed at Lumpu at 2.30 p.m. In the absence of any senior officers, two doctors and the brigade major, Major Rex Kharbanda, received Kaul. 'Where is GOC 4 Division?' was Kaul's first query. 'I don't know, sir,' said Kharbanda, 'sometimes he is in Tawang, sometimes in Tezpur.' The corps commander then asked if all the troops of 7 Brigade had moved to Tsangdhar.

'Not yet, sir,' Kharbanda answered honestly.